Platts

S&P Global
Energy

Specifications Guide
Platts North Sea Sulfur De-escalator

Latest update: February 2026

Platts to assess Forties sulfur de-escalator at 25 cents/b from March

On February 25 2025, Platts announced that the sulfur de-escalator to be effective March 1, 2026, in Forties cargoes and related instruments in the Platts MOC assessment process would be 25 cents/b per 0.1% weight of sulfur over the 0.6% wt standard.

This is unchanged from February.

The March sulfur de-escalator should apply to cargoes loading from March 1, 2026.

Platts, part of S&P Global Energy, considers several indicators in the determination of the Forties de-escalator level, including the behavior of sweet and light crudes versus sourer and heavier streams in the North Sea and other competing regions, as well as the performance of refined products and refinery feedstocks, and the outright price of crude oil.

Outright crude prices extended gains through February on geopolitical tensions and a relatively stable US dollar. The Dated Brent benchmark rose $3.52/barrel, or 5.18%, between Jan. 26 and Feb. 24, to $71.33/b.

However, a recent easing in North Sea supply tightness and seasonal lull in demand have weighed on the physical Dated Brent differential which slipped $1.52/b in the six sessions to Feb. 24.

Notably, sulfur spreads between European crude oil grades indicated a clear divergence between sweet and sour segments through February.

The premium of Ekofisk over Forties rose 46 cents/b over Jan. 26 to Feb. 24, while the premium of Ekofisk over Johan Sverdrup rose 42 cents/b over the same period.

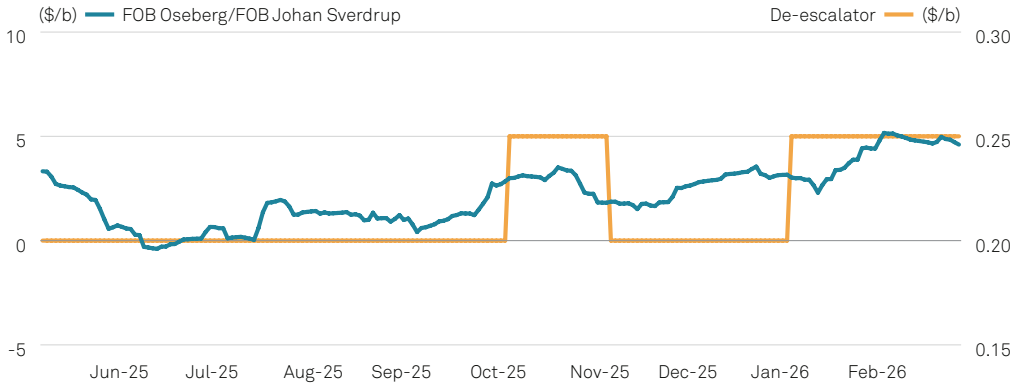
The premium of Oseberg over the Platts European Sour Crude Index (PESCI) rose by 30 cents/b, or 6.99%, over Jan. 26 to Feb. 24. The premium of Forties over the PESCI also increased, rising 12 cents/b over the same period.

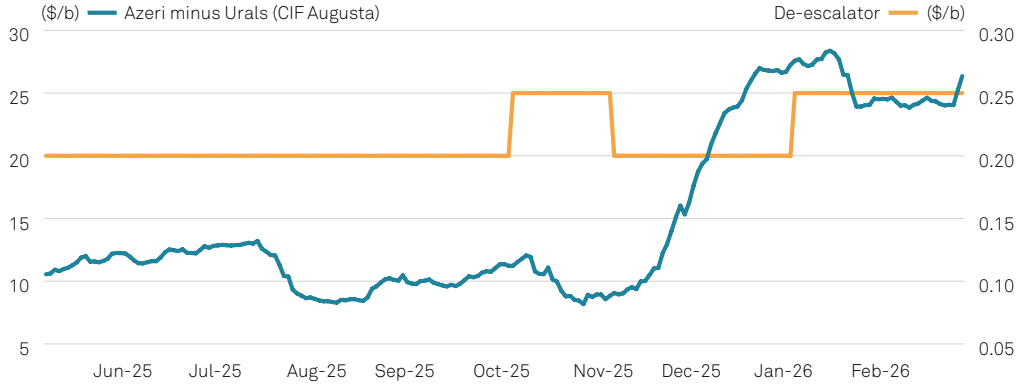
Volatility in CPC Blend supply through February has created a mixed picture within the Mediterranean crude complex. The discount of the flagship Kazakh crude to the PESCI narrowed $2.11/b over Jan. 26 to Feb. 24, while the premium of Azeri Light over heavy-sour Urals rose $2.29/b over the same period.

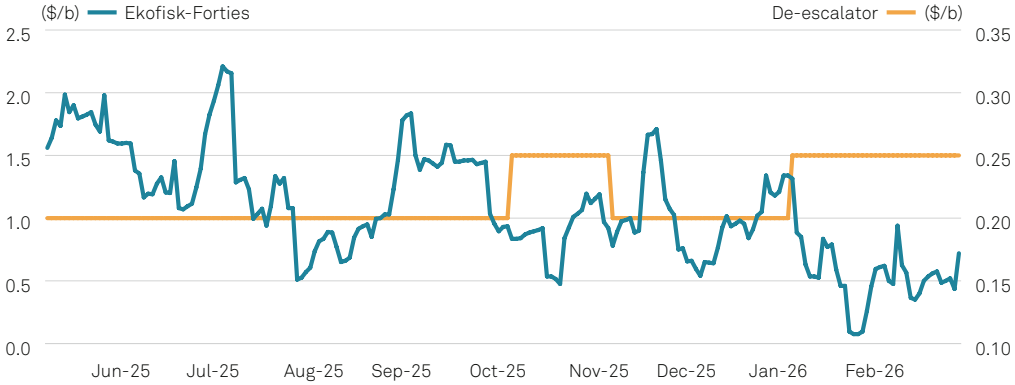
However, the spread between Azeri Light and Johan Sverdrup narrowed 19 cents/b over Jan. 26 to Feb. 24.

Notably, the Brent Dubai EFS, which reflects the spread between light sweet crude in the Western hemisphere and its heavy sour counterparts from the Eastern hemisphere, indicated a broader weakening of sweet crudes against their sour counterparts. The Platts-assessed Brent Dubai EFS narrowed 24 cents/b, or 11.11% over Jan. 26 to Feb. 24.

Sulfur spreads among refined oil products indicated a stronger premium for lower-sulfur products over more sulfurous ones.







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The Platts-assessed gasoline Eurobob FOB AR barge crack strengthened $4.59/b over Jan. 26 to Feb. 24. The Hi-5 spread, reflecting the premium of 0.5% sulfur fuel oil barges over 3.5% high sulfur fuel oil barges, widened $12/metric tonne over the same period, despite an improving HSFO crack. Middle distillate sulfur spreads also reflected a similar trend with CIF Northwest Europe 10ppm sulfur diesel cargoes strengthening $8.25/mt over the CIF NWE 0.1% sulfur gasoil between Jan. 26 and Feb. 24.

Although refined oil products indicated a congruent picture of widening sulfur spreads in the downstream market, several factors in the upstream market indicated slightly mixed directionality on the cost of sulfur.

Subsequently, the de-escalator was assessed unchanged for March, taking into account the falling physical Dated Brent differential and narrowing Brent Dubai EFS.

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